

RITE OF MEMORY

Mirza's partly autobiographical novel draws from memories of growing up under the idealism of his parents



AMMI: LETTER TO A DEMOCRATIC MOTHER

by SAEED MIRZA

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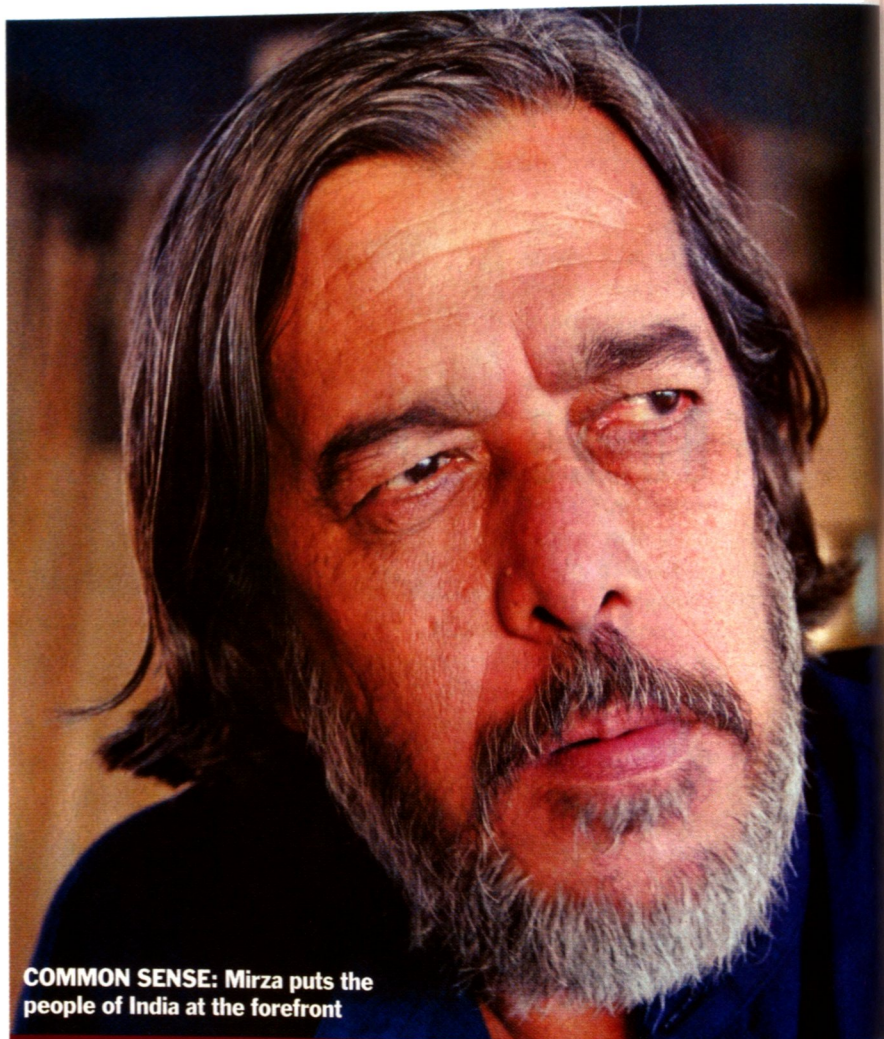
■ By Gillian Wright

The great Irish columnist Miles McGopaleen was always keen to consult what he called the Plain People of Ireland. He would place before them problems or dilemmas and they would respond with humour and sound common sense. Saeed Mirza, filmmaker and the creator of *Nukkar*, a uniquely popular comedy about ordinary men and women, puts the plain people of India at the forefront of his book. He finds them both exhilarating and humbling.

His novel is addressed to his mother but dedicated to his father, Farhat Akhtar Mirza, scriptwriter of the 1956 hit *Naya Daur*. The film tells the story of villagers uniting to build a road and thereby keep their jobs. Several of the true stories Mirza relates have echoes of *Naya Daur*. He meets villagers in Gaya, Bihar, who united across caste lines to build a canal. They were led by a social activist and an engineer. *Naya Daur* ends with the reconciliation of all foes, but this story belongs to an age where happy endings seem hard to come by. The engineer and the activist were both gunned down by goondas.

Before the second Iraq invasion, the plain people of the world took peacefully to the streets to oppose the war. Mirza again finds hope in the fact that they made their voices heard, even though they were ignored. He believes that this international movement disproves the theory of the clash of civilisations and demonstrates that all people share common human values.

But what has this to do with a novel? Is this book a novel at all? A lot of it is autobiography—Mirza's childhood in Mumbai, his career in advertising where he worked for one of India's most generous souls, Jog Chatterjee, his attraction to the Left and to Sufism.



COMMON SENSE: Mirza puts the people of India at the forefront

EXCERPT

When you died on the morning of the 7th of February 1990, you did so without a fuss, and in silence. Baba told us later that he saw you about to lie down in bed as he went in for a shower, and when he returned, you were gone. You had even arranged yourself with your sari and hair in place, your arms across the chest, your face composed. It was almost as if to tell the living to get on with it and just bury you: a practical, no-nonsense approach to death, as it was to life.

I also know that you passed away believing that both your sons were away—that could not have been a very comforting thought. What you did not know was that I had returned to Bombay the night before but instead of phoning you, as I usually did after a trip, I fell asleep, too tired to make that call.

'Why don't you call Ammi?' Jennifer had asked. 'I'll do it tomorrow,' I had replied. Tomorrow, as they say, was another day. Would that phone call have changed the course of events? I don't think so, but it might have been of some solace to you. As for me, it would have been nice to hear your voice one last time. Perhaps this letter is being written because of that missed call. There are so many things I need to talk to you about.

Let me begin with the news. I remember how you always wanted to be absolutely up to date with world events. I remember the one hour you would spend reading your morning Urdu newspaper and the half hour of watching the news on television.